

Semester 2 - 2024
OART1097 - Principles of Play 2
Game Creative Response



THE DEVIL'S DIALOGUES



HOW DEVIL MAY CRY ATTRACTS MALE AUDIENCE



Transcript - Research

Podcast Transcript

[INTRO]

Quyen (00:07)

Hello, hunters. Welcome back to the Devil's Dialogues, where we'll gather, have a sip, and talk about the Devil May Cry Franchise. If you're new, hi, it's your host, Quyen, speaking. Previously, we had so much fun diving into how the poem, The Divine Comedy, shapes the development of our franchise with Dr. Agnieszka. In today's episode, we'll talk about how the design of Devil May Cry is a charm to male audiences. Accompanying me today are four ssstylish devil experts. Welcome Thao

Thao (00:38)

Hello!

Quyen (00:40)

Linh

Linh (00:41)

What's up?

Quyen (00:42)

Thinh

Thinh (00:43)

Hi!

Quyen (00:43)

And Huy

Huy (00:44)

Howdy!

Quyen (00:45)

Yay. Thank you all for coming! It's just great to have the dream team here because I've just read your research about gender representation in Devil May Cry. It's just published like a month ago, right? The topic is fresh and new. I've never seen it before, especially in our franchise. I think that we should expand it more and more hunters should know about this. Now let's dive in, shall we?

Thinh, Thao, Linh, Huy (01:11)

Yeah. Let's go.

Quyen (01:13)

Right, so what do you think are THE factors that appeal to male audiences the most in Devil May Cry?

Thinh (01:21)

Before answering your question, we want to make it clear that our research is mostly based on Western and some of the Asian markets.

Quyen (01:29)

Okay~

Thinh (01:30)

I think one of the most important aspects that attract males in Devil May Cry is the genre and the style of the game. Based on research by Kristen and John in 2004, I found that males are really into action and competitive games. Look back at Devil May Cry, it features both elements that appeal to males.

Quyen (01:54)

Oooh, well, I understand that Devil May Cry contains many action aspects in the game, but what about the competition? Is it shown clearly in the game?

Thinh (02:09)

The competitive aspect of Devil May Cry that we can see is the rating and scoring system in the game. It motivates players to put themselves to achieve a high score if possible to compare their results with friends and others in fandom. This aspect is often known by someone who tries hard in the game and not really cared by someone playing for experiment or joy.

Quyen (02:37)

So it's not for casual gamers, right? All right.

Linh (02:40)

I feel like besides gameplay, the visual design of Devil May Cry is also an important side to attract male audience.

Quyen (02:40)

Visuals~

Linh (02:41)

Yeahh. So, to begin with, I think the connection between the visuals and the violence aspect is what attracts male players.

Quyen (03:00)

Ooooh, can you go into more detail about it?

Linh (03:04)

Oh, yeah, sure. Why not? But before I go into more detail, our team just want to say that we don't plan to create any stereotype about male interest in both violence and the Gothic style because we didn't find any statistics about the LGBT community. So in this research, we will only focus on the heterosexual male community. I actually found multiple studies that show that men tend to prefer the violence and competition video games. And you know, if you see in other media entertainment, the violence aspect is kinda widely seen in comic books, action movies, and dark fantasy novels. Also in Devil May Cry, I think the gothic environments, horror-inspired creatures, and the punky visual art style also contribute to the emphasis of the violence aspect, which is usually shown in scenes where players have to kill the monsters.

Thao (04:24)

So aside from the environment and the violence things, I think the female character designs are also an aspect that attracts male players. So I've seen the female player character designs in Devil May Cry are usually emphasized with physical features, such things as attractive faces and also, revealing outfits.

Quyen (04:46)

Yeah, that is so true. Like in our game, Trish and Lady are really famous for having the designs based on those traits that you've just said. For example, Lady, she wears an outfit that has extremely short shorts and a quite revealing top I would say.

Linh (05:08)

Yeah, I agree with that. I also found research indicating that these kinds of portrayals of female characters actually will help to attract the attention of male players to the game. I think the image of sexualized female character design in Devil May Cry also serves as a fan service that appeals to male, right?

Quyen (05:35)

Yes. Yeah.

Thao (05:38)

Another thing that attracts male related to culture is the male representation in Devil May Cry, which is pretty dominant. So, If you see the male characters and their roles in the series, you will see they play a central role. For example, Dante plays as a protagonist, whereas Vergil plays as an antagonist, and Nero is a protagonist from Devil May Cry 4. Another thing to consider is the multiple definitions of masculinity. So compared to the female characters, male characters in the series have a variety of aspects of masculinity.

Quyen (06:18)

So what do you think about masculinity that is represented in Devil May Cry?

Huy (06:23)

Actually, at first, you have Dante as a classic restless male, and Nero, who brings out a vulnerable side which feels more relatable to the players. Then there's Vergil. He's always competing for power, but it's not just about fighting. His brotherhood rivalry strengthens male relationships in real life.

Thao (06:50)

Yeah. So according to the Book of Psychology of Man that I read, the reason for this can be related to things named masculinity ideologies. In the book, it said at a social level, masculinity ideologies can structure the subjective consequences of self-concept and male role standards. An example for this is the ideology that affects men's willingness to take risks, which can be seen in the character of Dante and Virgil. And the similar ideologies can be seen in environments where men have to undergo danger.

Huy (07:27)

Dangerous environment, like in the military!

Thao (07:30)

Yeah, that's right. The representation of ideology in this series would allow the audience, player audience, particularly male, to explore various aspects of masculinity in male characters.

Quyen (07:44)

That is such an interesting aspect, really. But speaking of male representation, it seemed pretty trendy in the early 2000s, around the birth of Devil May Cry, because back then, games were pretty much labeled exclusively for boys, as we can observe from the game merchandise and boys playing PlayStation 2 in advertisements and so on. Do you think that marketing has something to do with this phenomenon?

Huy (08:17)

Actually, this relates to the marketing approaches-consequences. Around 2001 to 2005, the gaming industry was marketed as "boy toys". A big part of that was the way the industry targeted young men. So, according to the ESA 2003, Essential Facts Report, 72% of video game's players were male, and that statistic sharpened the way games were advertised.

Thinh (08:54)

Yeah, I see the game has a masculine theme like action and violence. Everything makes young men like this game I make for them and it's worked..

Linh (09:07)

Well, so if you guys look at games like Super Mario or GTA. You can see they are not just popular for their gameplay, but also for their whole image, right? So it's no wonder why people are starting to see this game as primarily for boys.

Huy (09:27)

Exactly. And on the other hand, the female audience was really disadvantaged. Only 28% of gamers were women, according to that 2003 report, and the response was to market almost exclusively to men to reinforce the “boys' toy” image. It shows how gaming was seen for years until today.

Linh (9:53)

Yeah, I get your idea. But I want to add that the video game box art is also a marketing strategy aspect that I think companies used to target male audience. So I found a 2007 study. I found out 90.2% in the covers are men, while only 42.7% are women. So it's kind of weird, right?

Thao (10:30)

It's a low percentage of females. And speaking of portrayed women, I can tell that most of the time back then, if a female character appeared, they appeared with another male character, not only by herself. And this trend was also seen in popular games back then, like Mortal Kombat or Resident Evil, even Devil May Cry.

Thinh (10:52)

I have an interesting example of video game marketing that has mainly targeted men. It's Nintendo's Game Boy. When the Game Boy launched, the ads mostly featured men. And often showed them playing games in dynamic and adventurous scenarios. This helped create the image of video games as a hobby primarily for men. Even the name, the boy, is also a male's aspect.

Huy (11:28)

I personally liked the Game Boy.

Quyen (11:30)

Yeah, I think the arcade is fun, the machine is fun, but the name...

Thao (11:36)

But I think Nintendo should have included Game Girls along with Game Boy.

Quyen (11:42)

If it was a thing back then, it would have been so bomb. Wow, the last minutes, fantastic. We all have a closer look at how male audiences were directed in Devil May Cry. Not only through the game elements themselves, like the flashy gameplay, the funky art style, and the leading characters who are males. But also the influence of the early game marketing strategies that is just rooting for male audiences. Thank you so much Thao, Linh, Thinh, and Huy for joining me and having delivered such a sensational talk today. Thank you so much! And we're forever grateful to our dear hunters for keeping up with the discussion. I'm your host Quyen, and this is The Devil's Dialogues. Until next time!

[OUTRO]

Research/ Script Outline

QUYEN

Introduction

- Podcast series: The Devil's Dialogues
- Previous guest - topic: Dr. Agnieszka - Divine Comedy
- **Topic intro:** How Devil May Cry appeals to male audiences

Body

- Question 1: What elements?
- Question 2: Marketing and male representation (Q1 follow-up)
- Respond guests accordingly

Conclusion

- Topic wrap-up: Devil May Cry attracts males through:
 - Game elements: [adj] gameplay, [adj] art style, [adj] leading male characters ([adj]s shifts according to each element's vibe)
 - Marketing as "an accomplice"
- Thank guests & listeners

THINH

Gameplay

- Genre and style that attracts males (Kristen Lucas and John L. Sherry, 2004)
- The competitive aspect does not show clearly: can be seen in the rating and scoring system

Marketing Example: GameBoy

- GameBoy mainly targeted male players

LINH

Visual

- Emphasize on not intending to create the stereotype of male audiences liking violence and the Gothic style
- Then Talk about the connection between the visuals of Devil May Cry and the violence aspect that helps attract male audiences. Studies that show men tend to prefer the violence and competition video games.(Lucas and Sherry, 2004; Hartmann et al., 2015)
- Female character design in Devil May Cry also serves as a "fan-service" that appeals to male.

Marketing Example: Game box arts

- Box art cover is also a marketing strategy that targets male audiences.

- Statistic: 90.2% of the covers with humans portrayed men while only 42.7% portrayed women. (Melinda C. R. Burgess et al. (2007))

THAO

Male Representation:

- Show how the male representation in Devil May Cry is dominant:
 - Male characters play a central role in the Series: Protagonist; Antagonist
 - Male characters have a different aspect of masculinity.
- Explain how the portrayal of dominant males attracts male audiences and its relation to masculinity ideologies: At a social level, masculinity ideologies structure the subjective consequences of self-concept and male role standards. (Levant & Pollack 1999)

HUY

Male Representation:

- Explain the evolution of male representation throughout the series.
 - Classic restless image, Dante
 - Rival and thrive for power(goal), Vergil
 - Emotional but relatable, Nero

Marketing Approaches & Consequences:

- Explain the Essential Facts report's statistics from 2001 to 2005, the gaming industry was marketed primarily as "boy toys" due to a large male player base (72%, ESA 2003)
 - Industries heavily targeted young men with action and violent games to promote the masculine image of gaming.
 - Also highlights the small number of female gamers to prove that the market was creating its own stereotypes. (28% ESA 2003)

UPDATED REFERENCE LIST

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